

Republicans retain razor-thin lead in Senate race

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【メール原文】

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Semiconductor tariffs likely to be further delayed

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Bessent is narrowing his ambitions as the limits on his toolkit become apparent

Republicans retain razor-thin lead in Senate race. Democrats have extended their run of good polling through August, with their candidates maintaining small leads in all competitive races except Iowa.

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However, we are maintaining our call that Republicans are the narrow favorites in the contest for the Senate (55%): they have a structural advantage, needing to win fewer toss-ups than Democrats to keep control of the Senate.

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We had previously set out three signposts for flipping our call towards Democrats: a Democratic generic ballot lead of at least 8.5 points; a fall in President Donald Trump's approval rating below 36%; and continued Democratic polling leads into mid-September. None of those have been met, and we will reevaluate the race later this month based on them.

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Strong Democratic candidates running against lackluster GOP campaigns make Ohio and Texas serious Republican vulnerabilities, while Alaska presents another real Democratic pickup opportunity, albeit one that will be hard to track given sparse polling and the complexities of ranked-choice voting.

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For more, please see [Republicans maintain razor-thin lead in Senate race](#) , 8 September 2026.

Semiconductor tariffs likely to be further delayed. Discussion of semiconductor tariffs is part of a pattern dating back to Liberation Day, and action on them has been delayed in the past to avoid disrupting US-China relations.

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The renewed debate on semiconductor tariffs—with Commerce Secretary Howard Lutnick reportedly pushing for action—likely reflects a July milestone in the ongoing Section 232 investigation rather than a shift in policy direction.

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Any tariff push will probably lose momentum in the short term, as Lutnick's influence on White House technology policy appears constrained and an upcoming summit between Trump and President Xi Jinping discourages provocative moves in this area.

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If the US eventually does impose semiconductor tariffs, the framework agreement with Taiwan would be the likely template, though key questions on tariff offsets remain unresolved.

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For more, please see US semiconductor tariffs likely to be further delayed , 8 September 2026.

Bessent is narrowing his ambitions as the limits on his toolkit become apparent. On 20 August, Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent declared that yields "didn't reflect the underlying fundamentals." On 31 August, after a global bond selloff that sent US yields above pre-intervention levels, his message shifted and he conceded that Treasury "cannot change the market's equilibrium price," describing his job as "to speed things down"—a sign he is leaning toward backing down rather than escalating.

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Bessent can still lean on the tools Treasury fully controls—including shifting more issuance toward short-term debt, buying back more long bonds, and intervening again in currency markets—but they are unlikely to significantly lower long-term yields.

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The administration would gain little from escalating to financial repression, pressure on the Federal Reserve, or coercion of foreign holders, as these measures are unlikely to work and could ultimately raise the premium investors demand to hold Treasuries.

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For more, please see Overview of US Treasury's toolkit to try to lower yields, 8 September 2026.

Quote of the Day

"Why is it record long? How long were we in Vietnam? We're in 5 months now." - Trump responding to a question about lengthy troop deployments during the war with Iran; with neither domestic opinion nor the midterm elections major factors in Trump's thinking on US involvement in Iran, he is likely to be comfortable maintaining the current standoff in the Strait of Hormuz through the end of the year, in line with Eurasia Group's basecase (60% odds).

On the Radar

10 August – 14 September: Senate on recess

9-10 September: GOP midterms convention

18-28 September: High-Level Week at UN General Assembly

24 September: Trump-Xi summit

3 November: National midterm elections

11 December: Government funding runs out

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